Big Mac, Strawberry Shake and Large Fries

By Jared Botticelli

NOTE: Contains triggering labels used against the LGBTQ Community

Apollo, a young man, somewhere between 17 and manhood, picks up a cup and takes a long drink through a straw. He looks with appreciation at the cup and then puts it down.

Strawberry shakes rock my world. No kidding. Right now, I can't really think of anything that makes me happier than a friggin' Micky D's strawberry shake. My boys always gave me crap about ordering strawberry, but ya know what, Real Men drink Strawberry. I kid ya not. *Apollo picks up his Big Mac and pulls the paper back. He takes a bite.* Add in one of these beauties, and, well, you've died and gone to Big Mac heaven. *He eats the last bite of his burger, crumples the paper into a ball and tosses it. He calls out to someone other than the audience before him.* 'K, I'm done. I'M DONE.

Uh, so it's kinda funny, but that's what I had that night. You know, "The Night of the Incident," as everybody and their mother likes to call it. Okay, hold up. Hold up. I need to give some history here. Get you guys up to speed with all of this.

INTRODUCTION

* *In 2023 over 550 anti-LGBTQ bills have been introduced into state houses across the county; more than 80 have been passed into law.* ***Record-breaking.*** *And against this backdrop of discriminatory legislation, attacks on the LGBTQ community are on the rise. Hate-filled rhetoric from our politicians and on social media leads to real world violence. 2022 saw the highest number of anti-LGBTQ hate crimes reported to date and the number are not yet in for 2023.*

Welcome to a hate crime – or as Apollo likes to call it "The Night of the Incident."

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Was me, Peach and Slideshow that night. Three of us boys, We'd just been out driving in my Mustang. Cherry Red. My Mom and Pops bought it for me for graduation. Only had it for coupla months. So, anyway, we're out driving around, went to McDonalds, and umm, Peach used his fake ID to score us some beer at 711

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and we drive down to that park in Midtown. Ya know, Triangle Park. The cops don't usually go through there at night, so that's where we'd go to drink or whatever. So, that night, we're sitting on the wall, drinkin, talking about going away in the fall, right?

We'd been there awhile when we see this dude walkin down the sidewalk across the street. We could see him, ya know, plain as day with the streetlights and what-not. And Peach and Slideshow, they start laughing, right? They start bustin up because he looks like. . . he looks like he's queer, ya know? Like he's gay. Tight jeans like a chick would wear, muscle tee, whatever. We knew he was walking home from the gay bars, right? Cuz there like two or three blocks down from the park or whatever. And umm, we start yelling crap across the street to him. Stupid stuff, ya know. "Hey homo," "Why don't you come over here and show us what you're good for?" -- Just teasin', right? And then, umm, somebody yells, "Faggot" and this guy, he turns and he yells back, "S**** you." And see, the thing is, ***that's*** what started all this. If he'd just kept walkin', none of this woulda ever happened . . . but, he yelled back.

And then, umm, all of a sudden we're not sittin' on the wall anymore, somehow we're across the street, right where the dude was walkin'. And somehow, Slideshow has the bat from the back of my 'Stang, and that guy, that gay dude, is down on the cement, and his arms and legs are goin' all crazy, like an octopus or something, just swinging around, and Slideshow, he's holdin' that bat just like when we were in high-school. And then, Slide is swinging the bat and he connects, but he's not hittin' a ball, he's hittin' this dude, and he swings and hits; swings and hits; swings and hits and the guy is making these sounds like a wild animal, cryin' out, growling, begging, screamin', all this stuff all at once.

And, uh, then Peach takes the bat and he swings too, and he hits this dude, like a buncha times. Then we're all just kinda standin there, ya know? And uh, Peach, he says to me, "Do it, man, you gotta do it. Just like a pinata. Just like a pinata, man."

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And, uh, see the thing is, I wasn't gonna hit him at all, ya know? He was busted up bad already, and, uh, I thought we should just split, right? So, I'm just standin' there, not doing anything, and Slideshow says, "What's the deal, Apollo? You wanna kiss the queer and make him better? What are ya, queer, Apollo?"

I'm not, of course, and my boys they know that, but I got so pissed off that I took the bat, my bat, and I'm looking at this guy on the ground and he's bleedin real bad, but he can still talk, can still yap, ya know? And he looks up at me and he just says one thing, jus' one. He says, "Tell my Mom I love her," and I swung the bat and when it connected it was like hittin' something soft, but then there was this cracking and I'm swinging and swinging and then, I dunno, I hear Peach say, "Dude, that's enough man, we gotta split. The queer might have AIDS. . . we gotta go get this off." And I realize there's all this blood. So much blood. Like the three of us are in a horror movie or somethin. So we split. And we left that guy on the sidewalk.

The dude's name was John Smith. And, guess what, he was a gay guy. Had a boyfriend or life partner or whatever they call it. He was 25. He died in the ambulance on the way to the hospital.

And, uh, by morning it's all over the papers and on the news. And Peach, he doesn't even last a day before he squeals to the cops. So I get arrested and that's when everything starts goin' really bonkers, ya know? And my Mom and Pops they get this team of lawyers, and they come every day and ask me questions about everything. Stuff that doesn't have anything to do with "The Night of the Incident." I have to answer questions about my family and Peach and Sideshow and whether I've ever had a girlfriend (negatory on that front -- never found one that met my standards, ya know?) and they just keep askin' all of these questions, and then the trial starts. And, I guess, to tell ya the truth, that's where I get a little sketchy on everything. It just went on forever.

I started to see it like a circus. Like I was six again or somethin' and I'm at the circus with my pops. And the lawyers are all lions growling at each other, and all the people that came and

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talked about blood types and stains and splatters are just clowns and some of them have happy faces and some of them have sad faces, and the judge, this old bald guy with big glasses, he's the ringleader, ya know? Directing all of them. It's like I could smell the popcorn and hear that music, the circus music, just playing on a loop over and over again. My lawyers did good though, they did, they tried to help me, tried to say it was Peach who beat the dude last and that it wasn't my bat and they used words I didn't even know, like "Narcissistic Personality" and "Internalized Homophobia" and, uh, the thing is though, I did it. I did. His blood was on my clothes, in my 'Stang, everybody knew I did it. And so, one day we're at the circus, the trial, and this District Attorney, she's grillin' me, askin' me the same dumb questions over and over again,

- "How many times did you strike Mr. Smith with the baseball bat?"
- "Did you intend for Mr. Smith to die?"
- "Did you mean to strike Mr. Smith in the head?"

And the circus music is just like drillin' a hole in my head and I'm feelin' like I'm gonna puke and I just see red, all this red blood all over everywhere and I put my head down and then I just said it. I just lost it. I did.

(Yelling) **"I killed him, okay? I knew I was gonna kill him when we went over there. I beat his head in with a bat, okay? I killed him."** *(long silence)*

I don't even know why. I just did. It was like I was the one bleedin' all over before I yelled and then afterwards, everything was quiet. And I look out across the circus and I see my Mom, ya know? And she's just mouthing "I love you" over and over again. It was over pretty quick after that.

I had to meet with all kinds of shrinks to make sure I wasn't crazy. . . and well, they decided I wasn't. I'm not an expert on life or anything, but I guess shit just happens sometimes. Anything coulda changed that night. I coulda gotten food poisoning from my Big Mac or we could agon to see Slideshow's girl, or I coulda told Peach . . . whatever. Ya know what I mean, right? It coulda turned out way different is my point. But it didn't. I'm not a bad kid, I just did something screwed up.

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Someone from outside the audience addresses Apollo and he responds to them.

Huh? It's almost time. Gotcha. I gotta finish my fries first. I always leave my fries 'til last. Cuz they burn my tongue when they're hot.

I told Mom I was gonna be really brave about all this. But uh, right now . . . I . . . umm, I don't wanna sound like a Marna's boy or anything, but when I was a little kid Mom used to sing this song to me, the mountain song, ya know, *(singing)* ***"She'll be coming 'round the mountain when she comes, she'll be pulling six white horses when she comes. . .*** and so, I'm just gonna kinda sing that all the way through, all the way, ya know?

I really love my Mom. I won't be able to see her through that mirror thing, but I know she's gonna be there . . . Hey, if you guys see her or whatever, you let her know that it wasn't her fault.

They say the gas chamber is like you're drowning -- like you're goin' out to sea and ya never come back. They say you gotta breathe in deep, real deep, ya know? So that's what I'm gonna do. I don't wanna drown. So I'm gonna breathe in deep . . . real deep. I'm gonna let the sea take me home. *Apollo responds again to an unseen voice.* Okay, okay. Jeez. I just got a fry or two left. Yup. I gotcha.

(singing) ***She'll he coming 'round the mountain when she comes She'll be comin' round the mountain when she comes. . .***

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jared Botticelli
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AWARD HISTORY

2007 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier2017 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier
NIETOC
KS State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier

**** Introduction Data Source***
The Epidemic of Violence (2023 Report) by The Human Rights Campaign
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